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Joshua Nations

Ruth

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Ruth

A. Theme and Background.

1. If Judges is considered one of the darkest books in the Bible, Ruth is considered one of the brightest; it is a gem of a book. The events of the book place it during the time of the judges, sometime in the period of 1160 to 1100 BC. Jewish tradition gives Samuel credit as the author. It was written sometime after the anointing of King David as the final verses in the book speak to David's genealogy.
2. It is a book of love. First the love of Ruth, for her mother-in-law Naomi. It is also a love story of the romance between Ruth and her future husband Boaz.
3. It is also a story of redemption. Boaz, as the kinsman redeemer, prefigures Christ as our kinsman redeemer in the New Testament.
4. It is a short book; only four chapters consisting of 84 verses. It is one of only two books named in the Bible after women and the only one named after a gentile woman.
5. The book of Ruth is a demonstration of the providence of God. Divine providence is God working through the natural order of things to accomplish His extraordinary purposes. We see divine providence as taught by the Apostle Paul in Romans 8:28: "We know that in all things God works for the good of those who love Him, who have been called according to His purpose." We see "all things" being worked out for the good of Naomi, Ruth and Boaz in these chapters.

1.

B. Chapter One.

1. The book opens with a famine in Israel. Naomi lives in Bethlehem with her husband and two sons. Due to the famine, they migrate to Moab. Naomi's husband dies and her two sons marry Moabite women, Orpah and Ruth. After ten years, both her sons die, and Naomi is now without a husband or sons.
2. When Naomi hears that the Lord has provided food for His people in Israel, she purposes to go back to the land of Judah. At first, both women state their intentions to go, but Naomi insists that there is no future for them to marry again. After many tears, Orpah kisses Naomi goodbye but Ruth clings to her and says

“where you go, I will go and where you stay, I will stay. Your people will be my people and your God will be my God” (vs. 16).

3. They return to Bethlehem and the entire community was stirred because of them (vs. 19). They arrive at the beginning of the barley harvest.

C. Chapter Two.

1. Ruth asks Naomi to let her go into the fields and pick up the leftover grain from the reapers. She picks a field that happens to belong to a relative of Naomi's on her husband's side by the name of Boaz. She finds favor in his sight, and he tells the workmen to leave extra grain for her. Boaz addresses her as “My daughter” (vs. 2:8) which might indicate that he is much older than she. He had heard of her faithful care for Naomi and says to her “May the LORD repay you for what you have done. May you be richly rewarded by the LORD, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge” (vs. 2:12).
2. Ruth returns to her home and tells Naomi that the place she has been working belongs to Boaz. Naomi tells her that he is one of their kinsman-redeemers. A kinsman redeemer is a close relative who under Levitical law (Leviticus 25:25), can redeem or buy back property of one who is poor. Naomi also tells her to remain in Boaz's field and work with the women there, as she might be harmed in someone else's field. This points out the chaos present in Israel under the judges.

D. Chapter Three.

1. Naomi tells Ruth that she needs to find a home where she will be well provided for. She instructs her to go to the field where Boaz and his men are winnowing barley on the threshing floor. She is told to wash, put on perfume and her best clothes and to uncover Boaz's feet and lie at his feet and that he will tell her what to do.
2. She waits until Boaz eats and drinks and lies down. Ruth goes and uncovers his feet and lies down. In the middle of the night, he wakes up startled and asks who this is. She tells him that she is his servant Ruth, and that he should cover her with the corner of his garment, as he is their kinsman-redeemer. He agrees but tells her that there is a relative that is closer and that he has first obligation to redeem them.
3. The ritual Ruth enacted seems very strange to our modern culture. But it is very significant. In Biblical times, the hem of a ruler or official represented their authority. The woman with the issue of blood touched the hem of Jesus' garment

and was healed (Luke 8:43-48). Ruth's action was appealing to his authority as the kinsman-redeemer. Some misinformed bible critics attempt to say this was a sexual encounter but, they are in extreme error.

E. Chapter Four.

1. Boaz goes to the town gate where legal matters were settled in biblical times. The closer relative is passing by, and Boaz has him set down. He explains that Naomi is selling a piece of land and that he has first position to redeem it. He agrees, but then Boaz says that he must also marry Ruth the Moabite and raise up offspring to Naomi's deceased husband. Hearing this, he refuses, as it might endanger his own estate. He tells Boaz that he should do it.
2. The next of kin takes off his sandal, which was a sign of legalizing a transaction in those days. The elders of the city who witnessed the transaction wish blessings upon Boaz and Ruth.
3. Boaz marries Ruth, and they have a son whom they named Obed, who was the father of Jesse, the father of David. The book concludes with the genealogy of King David.

F. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Deuteronomy 23:3 says that no Moabite may enter the assembly of the Lord unto the tenth generation. This was due to the incestuous relationship of Lot and his daughters which resulted in the Moabite people. Some have calculated the generations to Ruth and determined that she was the 11th generation. What does that tell you of God's curses against sin as well as His faithfulness in placing Ruth, a Moabite widow in the genealogy of Christ?
2. Some Bible teachers use the closer relative to Naomi who had first right to redeem her as representing the law. The law could not redeem us but Boaz representing grace and love can. Could you use this as an illustration of God's grace and love for us in witnessing to your relatives and friends?
3. The kinsman-redeemer is a profound truth in Scripture. Boaz had to be related by blood to Naomi in order to have the authority to redeem her and Ruth. Christ also had to be related to us by blood in order to have the authority to redeem us. He had to be born of the virgin Mary as a genuine man but also as the genuine God-man in order to have the position to redeem us. Consider using this illustration in witnessing to others.

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)